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PART II

Traversing Borders

Contemporary Asian Immigration to the United States

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Contemporary Asian America

Immigration, Demographic Transformation, and Ethnic Formation

MIN ZHOU, ANTHONY C. OCAMPO, AND J. V. GATEWOOD

Anyone who rides the subway in New York, drives on the freeway in California, or walks into any urban classroom will immediately feel the impact of contemporary immigration. Large-scale, non-European immigration to the United States began in the late 1960s after a long hiatus due to restricted immigration and has accelerated at rapid speeds since the early 1990s. Between 1980 and 1999, more than 16 million immigrants immigrated into the United States, more than the total number of immigrants who arrived during first two decades of the twentieth century (14.6 million admissions between 1900 and 1919) when immigration was at its peak.¹ From 2000 to 2012, another 13.4 million immigrated legally to the United States as permanent residents. Unlike turn-of-the-twentieth-century immigrants, today's newcomers have come predominantly from non-European countries. Since the 1980s, 78 percent of the immigrants admitted to the United States have come from the Americas (excluding Canada) and Asia, only 12 percent from Europe, compared to more than 90 percent at the earlier peak. The share of immigrants from Asia as a proportion of the total admissions grew from a tiny 5 percent in the 1950s to 11 percent in the 1960s and to 33 percent the 1970s, and has remained at around 35 percent since 1980.² The Philippines, China, India, Korea, and Vietnam have been on the list of top ten sending countries since 1980. What caused this massive human movement in recent years, particularly from Asia? Who are these newcomers? How does the host society receive them? How do they affect US-born peoples of Asian descent who share their cultural heritage and their communities, and how are they affected by the natives and their new homeland? These questions are of central importance, as they will certainly determine the future of Asian America.

The Driving Forces behind Contemporary Immigration from Asia

US immigration legislation has always appeared humanitarian in principle and democratic in ideology. However, beginning with the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, Congress passed various laws to restrict immigration from the "barred zone" (known as the Asia-Pacific Triangle) and to single out Asian immigrants

for exclusion. Asian immigrants were not only barred from reentering the country, but also denigrated “aliens ineligible to citizenship,” were consequently deprived from owning land, attaining professional occupations, sending for their family members, marrying white Americans, and becoming equal participants in American society. World War II marked a watershed for Asian Americans since their homelands, Japan excepted, were allies of the United States. Congress repealed the Chinese Exclusion Act in 1943 and other Asian exclusion acts at the end of the war and passed the War Brides Act in 1945 to allow American GIs to reunite with their Asian wives in the United States. The public began to shift its perception of Asian Americans as “yellow peril” to “model minorities.” This change in perception included Japanese Americans, whose population—some 120,000 at its peak—languished in American-style concentration camps for the duration of World War II. Two-thirds of these prisoners were American citizens. In 1952, Congress passed the McCarran-Walter Act, making all national origin groups eligible for naturalization. While this act eliminated race as a barrier to immigration, it maintained the national origins quota system in immigration policy that limited migrants from specific regions to token numbers up until the late 1960s.

During the 1960s, at the time when the United States was entangled in an unpopular war against Vietnam while also in the throes of the civil rights movement, both international and domestic crises pushed Congress to clean up the remaining discriminatory immigration legislation. Meanwhile, labor market projections showed that an acute shortage of engineering and medical personnel would soon materialize unless the United States opened its door to foreign labor. In response, Congress passed the Hart-Celler Act in 1965. This landmark piece of legislation abolished the national origins quota system and strived toward two goals: to reunite families and to meet the labor market demand for skilled labor. Since the law went into effect in 1968, immigration from Asia and the Americas has accelerated rapidly, with little sign of slowing down. Between 1970 and 2012, a total of 11.4 million Asians were admitted into the United States as legal immigrants (not counting the thousands of refugees who began to arrive in the mid-1970s and the estimated one million Asian immigrants who remain undocumented).³ The majority of contemporary Asian immigrants were either family-sponsored migrants (more than two-thirds) or employer-sponsored skilled workers (about one-fifth). The Hart-Celler Act of 1965 has impacted Asian immigration, but the main driving forces are beyond the scope of US immigration policy. Recent changes worldwide—global economic restructuring, rapid economic development in Asia, and increasing US political, economic, and military involvement in Asia—have all combined to perpetuate Asian immigration to the United States.

The globalization of the US economy in the postindustrial era, particularly since World War II, has forged an extensive link of economic, cultural, and

ideological ties between the United States and many developing countries in the Pacific Rim. Globalization at this stage has perpetuated emigration from developing countries in two significant ways. First, direct US capital investments into developing countries transform the economic and occupational structures in these countries by disproportionately targeting production for export while taking advantage of raw material and cheap labor. Such twisted development, characterized by the robust growth of low-skilled jobs in export manufacturing, draws a large number of rural, and particularly female, workers into the urban labor markets. Increased rural-urban migration, in turn, causes underemployment and displacement of the urban workforce, creating an enormous pool of potential emigrants (Sassen 1989). Second, economic development following the American model in many developing countries stimulates consumerism and consumption and raises expectations regarding the standard of living. The widening gap between consumption expectations and the available standards of living within the structural constraints of the developing countries, combined with easy access to information and migration networks, in turn create tremendous pressure for emigration (Portes and Rumbaut 2014). Consequently, US foreign capital investments in developing countries have resulted in the paradox of rapid economic growth and high emigration from these countries to the United States.

On the US side, unprecedented growth in capital-intensive, high-tech industries and in services forecasts a severe shortage of skilled workers. American businesses and policymakers believed that importing skilled labor was the quickest solution. Since the 1980s, about one-third of the engineers and medical personnel in the US labor market have come from abroad—mostly from India, China, Taiwan, and the Philippines. However, the shortage of skilled labor is not a sufficient explanation for the trends in highly skilled migration, since skilled immigration disproportionately originates from selected countries in Asia (almost two-thirds of the total skilled immigration in 2012). It is the global integration of higher education and advanced training in the United States in interaction with the opportunity structure in the homelands that have set in motion the highly skilled immigration. The infusion of the educational systems with globalization in many developing countries—notably India, Korea, the Philippines, and Taiwan—has given rise to a sizable professional class within these countries. Many members of this emerging middle class are frustrated by the uneven economic development and lack of mobility opportunities at home that devalue their education and skills, and, in some cases, they also feel powerless to make changes because of repressive political systems in their homelands. They therefore actively seek emigration as a preferred alternative, and the change in US immigration policy has facilitated this move (Liu and Cheng 1994). Also, the emergence of the United States as the premier training ground for international students has been instrumental in supplying the US economy with needed skilled labor (Ong, Cheng, and Evans 1992). Many foreign students have found permanent employment in the United

States after completing their studies or practical training. For example, in 1995, close to 40 percent of the immigrants from mainland China were admitted under employment-based preferences. Almost all of them had received higher education or training in the United States.

In addition, Southeast Asian refugees constitute a significant share of contemporary Asian immigration. Since 1975, more than one million refugees have arrived from Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia as a direct result of the failed US intervention in Southeast Asia. The United States originally had little economic interest in Southeast Asia but was drawn in because of the threat of communist takeovers in the region. The development of the communist bloc dominated by the former Soviet Union, the communist takeover in China in the late 1940s, and the direct confrontation with communist troops in the Korean War prompted a US foreign policy aimed at “containing” communism, which ultimately dragged Americans into Indochina. The Vietnam War, its expansion into Southeast Asia, and political turmoil in the region left millions of people living in poverty, starvation, and constant fear, while forcing many others to flee from their homelands. One ironic consequence of the US involvement in Indochina is that sizable parts of the populations of Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia are now in America (Rumbaut 1995). By 1996, more than 700,000 refugees from Vietnam, 210,000 from Laos, and 135,000 from Cambodia had been admitted to the United States. Since then, Southeast refugee inflows have declined, but such decrease has been accompanied by a rapid increase of family-sponsored migrants from the region. As a result, these communities have experienced significant growth. According to the 2010 census, there are now 1.7 million Vietnamese, 232,000 Laotians, and 277,000 Cambodians living in the United States (US Census Bureau 2012).

Southeast Asian refugees fled their countries in different waves. Although Saigon, Vientiane, and Phnom Penh fell to the communist forces roughly at the same time in 1975, only the Vietnamese and a small number of the Hmong resistance force had the privilege of being “paroled” (being allowed under special provision of the law) into the United States immediately after the war. Approximately 130,000 Vietnamese refugees and only 3,500 Hmong refugees landed on US soil in 1975 (Chan 1994), while the majority of Hmong resistance forces, Laotian royalists, and Cambodians sought refuge in Thailand. During what is known as the second wave, a large refugee exodus occurred at the end of the 1970s when thousands fled Vietnam. About a quarter of a million Vietnamese refugees went to China, while some half a million floated in the open sea to be rescued by the national guards of whichever country they happened to be near. Almost half of the “boat people” were reported to have perished at sea, and the remaining half ended up in camps in Thailand, Indonesia, Malaysia, Singapore, the Philippines, and Hong Kong. Thousands of refugees also fled Laos and Kampuchea (formerly Cambodia) on land to seek refuge in crowded camps along the Thai border. Despite harsh repatriation efforts by the Thai government, about 600,000 Cambodians (15 percent of the

country's population) and some 100,000 Hmong and 200,000 lowland Laotians (10 percent of the country's population) fled on land to Thailand, awaiting resettlement in a third country (Chan 1991). The refugee exodus continued in large numbers in the early 1980s. Although the newly established governments in Southeast Asia did not plunge the three countries into a bloodbath as so many had once feared, continuing political and religious repression, economic hardship, incessant warfare, and contacts with the outside world led many Southeast Asians to escape in search of a better life (Zhou and Bankston 1998).

Once set in motion, international migration is perpetuated by extensive and institutionalized migration networks. Networks are formed by family, kinship, and friendship ties, facilitating and perpetuating international migration because they lower the costs and risks of movement and increase the expected net returns to such movement (Massey et al. 1987). US immigration policy has been instrumental in sustaining and expanding family migration networks. The Hart-Celler Act of 1965 and its subsequent amendments give preference to family reunification, providing immediate relatives of US citizens with unlimited visa numbers and other relatives with the majority of visa allocations subject to the numerical cap. More than two-thirds of the legal immigrants admitted to the United States since the 1970s have been family-sponsored immigrants. Even among employer-sponsored migrants and refugees, the role of networking is crucial. Family, kin, and friendship networks also tend to expand exponentially, serving as a conduit to additional and thus potentially self-perpetuating migration. Immigration from Asia is expected to continue at its high volume because many recent immigrants and refugees will have established citizenship status and will become eligible sponsors who can send for family members to reunite in the United States. In fact, in 2012 the Pew Research Center reported that Asians surpassed Hispanics as the largest immigrant population in the United States. According to the report, Asian Americans are the fastest growing minority group in the country.⁴

Overall, contemporary immigration has been influenced and perpetuated not simply as a result of the Hart-Celler Act but also by the interplay of a complex set of macro- and micro-structural forces. Understanding its dynamics requires a reconceptualized framework that takes into account the effects of globalization, uneven political and economic developments in developing and developed countries, the social processes of international migration, and the role of the United States in world affairs. One significant implication arising from these processes is that high levels of immigration will continue to remain an inseparable part of Asian American life for years to come.

The New Face of Asian America

Immigration is transforming Asian America in ways unanticipated by longtime Asian immigrants and their US-born children. Although Asian Americans as a

group are relatively few in number, making up 6 percent of the U. S. population, they have aggressively asserted their presence in the American milieu, fighting their way, with varied success, into mainstream economic, social, and political institutions. Before the immigration surge in the late 1960s, the Asian American population was a tiny fraction of the total US population—about a third of one percent in 1900 and 0.7 percent in 1970—and was composed mainly of three national-origin groups—Japanese, Chinese, and Filipinos. Figure 3.1 shows the percentage distribution of the Asian American population from 1900 to 2010 (Barringer, Gardner, and Levin 1993; US Census Bureau 2012). Prior to 1930, Asians in America were mainly either Chinese or Japanese, mostly immigrants. Between 1930 and 1970 the number of Filipinos increased significantly. Filipinos were mostly brought into the United States to fill the labor shortage caused by anti-Asian legislation and the restrictive National Origins Act of 1924. By 1970, Japanese Americans were the largest national origin group, making up 41 percent of the Asian American population, followed by Chinese Americans (30 percent) and Filipino Americans (24 percent). Members of other national origin groups (mostly Koreans) represented less than 5 percent of the total.

As Figure 3.1 shows, however, the heterogeneity of Asian American ethnicities increased tremendously by the end of the twentieth century. As of the latest census, Japanese compose less than a tenth of the Asian population. While Chinese and Filipino Americans remain the two largest Asian American groups, their proportion of the total Asian population decreased to 23 percent and 19 percent, respectively. While Japanese, Chinese, and Filipinos once dominated the Asian population, they constitute only about half of Asians today, due mainly to the exponential rise of the Korean, Asian Indian, and Vietnamese populations.

Pre–World War II immigrants from Asia represented less than 5 percent of the total new arrivals admitted to the United States, a direct result of anti-Asian prejudice and various restrictive immigration laws. Most of the earlier Asian immigrants came from China and Japan, with a smaller number from the Philippines, India, and Korea. These earlier immigrants, like “the tired, huddled masses” from Europe, were typically poor and uneducated peasants, and many of them intended to make a quick fortune to bring back to their homelands. Because of the drastic differences in migration histories among the earlier Asian-origin groups, only Japanese immigrants were able to develop family-based communities with a significant US-born population in the pre–World War II period. Chinatowns, the rather dispersed Filipino enclaves, and other Asian immigrant communities were primarily bachelor societies with single adult males overrepresented and with few women, children, and families (Chan 1991; Takaki 1989; Zhou 1992).

The distorted population growth in Asian American communities is living evidence of decades of legal exclusion and discrimination. From the time of their arrival, Asian immigrants were subject to laws that served to exclude them from the social and economic opportunities available to most white immigrants.

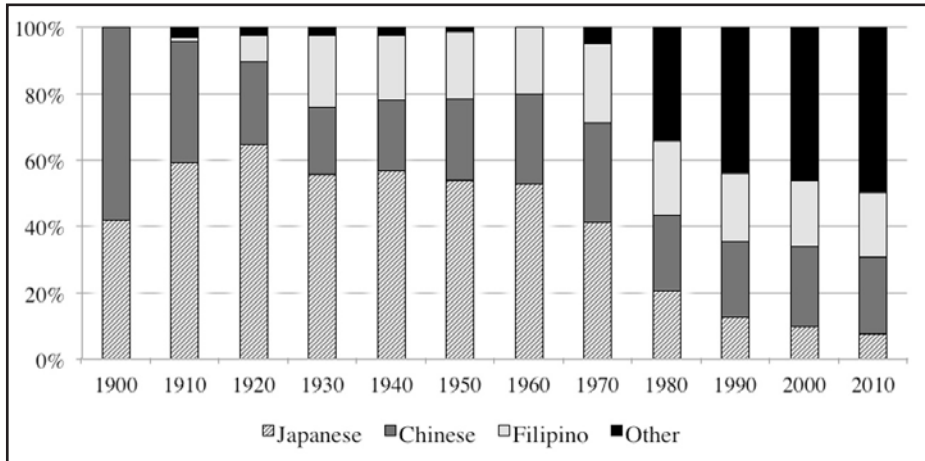


Figure 3.1. Percentage Distribution of Asian American Population, 1900–2010. *Source:* 1900–1970: Barringer, Gardner, and Levin (1993, 42); 1980–2010: US Census Bureau (1983, 1993, 2002, 2012).

Despite the eventual repeal of the laws that excluded Asian immigrants and barred them from the rights of naturalization, the Asian American population grew very slowly, making up barely half a percent of the total US population by 1950. The number of people in some Asian-origin groups was so miniscule, in fact, that the US census did not even categorize them until 1980 (Nash 1997).⁵ Nonetheless, the relaxation of immigration legislation during the early 1940s and 1950s, combined with a postwar baby boom, did give rise to a notable US-born youth cohort, most of whom lived on the West Coast. This group, comprising mostly Japanese and Chinese Americans, came of age in the late 1960s to form the core force of the Asian American movement at college campuses on the West Coast and in the Northeast.

The diversity of the Asian American population started to take shape during the 1970s. The dramatic increase in Asian immigration marked the beginning of contemporary Asian America. In sheer numbers, the US Asian and Pacific Islander population grew from a total of 1.4 million in 1970, to 7.3 million in 1990, to 12 million in 2000, to over 19 million in 2013 (in contrast to 205,000 in 1900), an impressive twelvefold increase in just four decades. Much of this growth is attributed to immigration, which has accounted for more than two-thirds of the total population growth. The population of most of the new national-origin groups—Indians, Koreans, Vietnamese, Cambodians, Laotians, and the Hmong—grew at spectacular rates, almost entirely because of immigration (Pew Research Center 2012). It was estimated that, if the current levels of net immigration, intermarriage, and ethnic affiliation hold, the size of the Asian population will increase from 12 million in 2000 to 34 million in 2050, growing from 4 to over 8 percent of the total US population (Smith and Edmonston 1997).

The recency of Asian immigration highlights two distinct demographic characteristics of the Asian American population: a disproportionately large foreign-born component and a general decline of the foreign-born component in all national-origin groups. As indicated in Figure 3.2, the foreign-born component dominates all Asian American groups, except for Japanese Americans. However, there is a large percentage drop in the proportion of the foreign-born (about 15 percent) for every group except for the Vietnamese. This demographic trend is a strong indication of a growing second generation—US-born children of foreign-born parentage. The great majority of the foreign-born is of working age. By contrast, the US-born Asian American population is an extremely young group. More than half of US-born Asian Americans are under eighteen years of age. One implication about this emerging new second generation is that it will grow up in an era of continuously high immigration, joined by a sizeable foreign-born youth cohort—the 1.5 generation—whose members are far more diverse in ethnic backgrounds, the timing of immigration, degrees of acculturation, orientation, and outlooks. This is a situation quite distinct from that which faced the second generation of immigrants in the 1950s and 1960s, because of restrictive immigration.

Diverse National Origins

The dramatic growth in absolute numbers of Asian immigrants has been accompanied by the increasing ethnic diversity within the Asian American population itself. As of 2010, the US census recorded thirteen national-origin or ethnic groups with populations exceeding 150,000, as revealed in Table 3.1. Since 1980, no single group has accounted for more than one-quarter of the Asian American population. While major national-origin groups—Japanese, Chinese, Filipino, Korean, Indian, and Vietnamese—were proportionally represented in 2000, other national-origin or ethnic groups—Cambodian, Laotian, the Hmong, Pakistani, and Thai—marked their presence in Asian America only very recently since the late 1970s. Because of the unique migration patterns in each of the originating countries, national origins are strongly associated with the type of legal admission (family-sponsored, employer-sponsored, or refugees) and with the skill levels of immigrants. For example, many Filipino immigrants to the United States are college graduates with transferable job skills; many are physicians and nurses sponsored by US employers in the health care industry. Indian immigrants are mostly employed as physicians and computer programmers, as well as small-business entrepreneurs (Dhingra, this volume). Koreans are predominantly middle-class professionals but tend to be disproportionately self-employed in small-scale retail trade. Chinese immigrants are more mixed, including fairly even proportions of rural peasants, urban workers, and the highly skilled. Southeast Asian refugees, in contrast, were pushed out of their

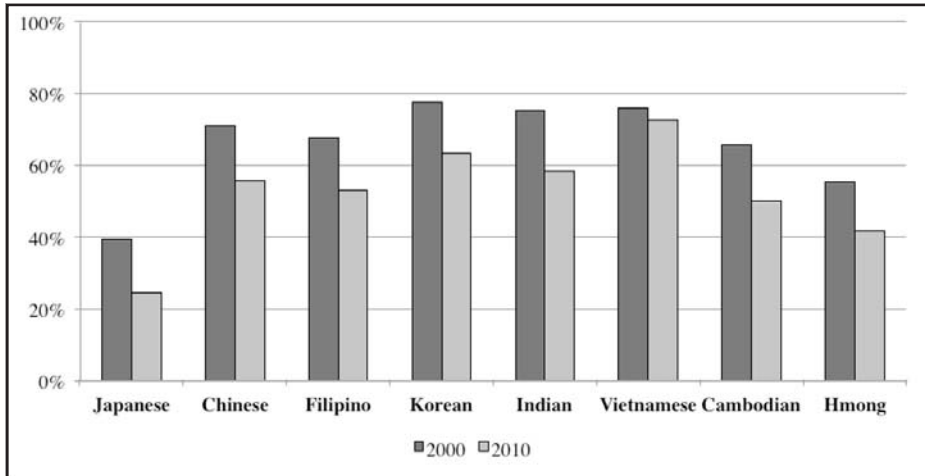


Figure 3.2. Asian American Population: Percentage Foreign-Born, 1900–2010. *Source:* US Census Bureau (2002, 2012).

homelands by force and suffer tremendous postwar trauma and social displacement, compounded by a lack of education and professional skills, which negatively affect their resettlement (Bankston and Hidalgo, this volume).

TABLE 3.1. Asian American Population, 1980–2000 (Thousands)

	1990	% Total	2000	% Total	2010	% Total
Chinese	1,545	22.8	2,858	24.1	4,010	23.2
Filipino	1,407	20.8	2,385	20.1	3,417	19.7
Japanese	848	12.5	1,152	9.7	1,304	7.5
Indian	815	12.0	1,856	15.7	3,183	18.4
Korean	799	11.8	1,227	10.3	1,706	9.8
Vietnamese	615	9.1	1,212	10.2	1,737	10.0
Cambodian	149	2.2	213	1.8	277	1.6
Pakistani	—	—	209	1.8	409	2.4
Laotian	147	2.2	197	1.7	232	1.3
Hmong	94	1.4	185	1.6	260	1.5
Thai	91	1.3	150	1.3	237	1.4
Other Asian	265	3.9	215	1.8	548	3.2
Total	6,775	100.0	11,859	100.0	17,320	100.0

Source: US Census Bureau (1993, 2002, 2012).

Diverse Socioeconomic Backgrounds

Another distinguishing characteristic of contemporary Asian America is the tremendous heterogeneity in diverse socioeconomic status. The 2012 Pew Research Center report attests to the vast differences in Asian Americans' levels of education, occupation, and income by national origins. In the aggregate, about half of all Asian Americans over the age of twenty-five have earned a college degree or higher, however educational attainment varies widely by ethnicity. For example, 70 percent of Indian American adults (aged twenty-five years or older) reported having attained bachelor's degrees or more, and more than 45 percent of Chinese, Filipino, Korean, and Japanese Americans reported so, but only 26 percent of Vietnamese Americans and fewer than 15 percent of Cambodian, Laotian, and Hmong Americans (compared to 28 percent of average American adults). While there has been a significant increase in the educational attainment levels of all groups over the past decade, the disparities are still strong.

Among employed workers (age sixteen years or older), about 60 percent of Indian Americans and more than half of Chinese and Japanese Americans held managerial or professional occupations, but about a quarter of Vietnamese and fewer than 20 percent reported so (compared to 34 percent of average American workers). Furthermore, Indian and Filipino Americans reported a median family income of more than \$70,000, and Chinese and Japanese Americans, more than \$60,000, but Korean and Southeast Asian families reported a median family income around or significantly below the national average of \$50,000. Poverty rates for Asian Americans ranged from a low of 6 percent for Filipinos and 10 percent for Indians and Japanese to a high of more than 38 percent for the Hmong and 29 percent for Cambodians (compared to about 12 percent for average American families) (Reeves and Bennett 2004).

Diverse Settlement Patterns

A third salient feature of contemporary Asian America is the diverse geographic settlement patterns of immigrants and their offspring. Historically, most Asian immigrants in the United States have been concentrated in Hawaii and in states along the Pacific Coast, with a small number of Chinese moving east to settle in New York. Within each area of settlement, they have been highly segregated in ethnic enclaves, such as Chinatowns, Little Tokyos, and Little Manilas. Today, geographic concentration continues to be significant as newcomers follow the footsteps of their predecessors to settle on the West Coast in disproportionate numbers (Zhou 2009; Zhou, Tseng, and Kim 2008). California remains the preferred destination for immigrants from Asian countries and has just over 30 percent of the nation's Asian American population, though this is a significant decline from 40 percent back in 2000. Tables 3.2 and 3.3 show the geographic

distribution of Asian Americans by metropolitan areas (PMSAs or MSAs),⁶ further confirming historical and contemporary patterns of ethnic concentration. Nonetheless, the Asian American presence in other parts of the mainland United States is growing—about 21 percent of Asian Americans live in the US South, another 20 percent in the Northeast, and about 10 percent in the Midwest.⁷

TABLE 3.2. Top Ten Metro Areas with Largest Asian American Population, 2010

	Total Population (Thousands)	Asian American Population (Thousands)	% Asian American
New York, NY	8,175	1,135	13.9
Los Angeles, CA	3,793	484	12.8
San Jose, CA	946	327	34.6
San Francisco, CA	805	289	35.9
San Diego, CA	1,307	241	18.4
Honolulu, HI	337	230	68.2
Chicago, IL	2,696	167	6.2
Houston, TX	2,099	140	6.7
Fremont, CA	214	117	54.7
Philadelphia, PA	1,526	107	7.0
Seattle, WA	609	101	16.6
Sacramento, CA	466	99	21.2
United States	281,421	17,320	4.6

Source: US Census Bureau (2012).

TABLE 3.3. Largest Asian American Population Growth, by Region and State, 2000–2010

	2000 (Thousands)	2010 (Thousands)	Percentage Increase
Region			
South	2,267	3,835	69.2
Midwest	1,393	2,054	47.5
Northeast	2,368	3,429	44.8
West	5,870	8,003	36.3
Top 10 states			
Nevada	112	243	116.0
Arizona	119	231	94.6
North Carolina	136	253	85.4

TABLE 3.3. (cont.)

	2000 (Thousands)	2010 (Thousands)	Percentage Increase
North Dakota	5	9	85.1
Georgia	200	365	82.9
New Hampshire	19	35	79.6
Delaware	19	34	77.9
Arkansas	25	45	76.9
Indiana	73	127	74.0
Texas	644	1,111	72.4
United States	11,898	17,320	45.6

Source: US Census Bureau (2012).

Nonetheless, the Asian American population has begun to disperse throughout the Northeast, the Midwest, and the South. For example, sizeable ethnic communities are found in New Orleans (Vietnamese), Houston (Vietnamese and Chinese), and Minneapolis (the Hmong), cities that traditionally received few Asian immigrants. Although there is still evidence of clustering along national or ethnic lines at the local level, there are very few examples of the large and distinctly monoethnic enclaves that were common in the past. In San Francisco, Los Angeles, and New York, there are no new Chinatowns where more than half of the residents are coethnics; Koreatowns in New York and Los Angeles, and Little Saigon in Orange County are no exception. Filipinos Americans and Indian Americans are comparatively more spread out across the urban landscape with few identifiable ethnic enclaves. For example, as of 2000, only 2 percent of Los Angeles County’s Chinese Americans lived in Chinatown (decreased from 12 percent in 1990), 7.4 percent of Korean Americans lived in Koreatown (decreased from 22 percent in 1990), and a tiny number of Japanese Americans (fewer than 700) lived in Little Tokyo. A recent report by the *Huffington Post* noted that urban ethnic enclaves have “wane[d] as Asians head to the suburbs.”⁸ Overall, trends of spatial integration (moving into white middle-class neighborhoods) and suburbanization among Asian Americans have been particularly strong in recent years, resulting in decreasing levels of residential segregation even in areas of high concentration.

Identity, Emerging Ethnicity, and the Assimilation Problem

“Who Am I?”

We ABC [American-born Chinese] were ridiculed by the old immigrants as “Bamboo Stick” for not being able to speak Chinese and not being accepted as “white people.” We are not here. We are not there. . . . We are different. Most of

us are proud of the Chinese cultural heritage, but due to the pressure to assimilate and the lack of opportunity, we don't know much about the Chinese way.⁹

The issue of identity has always occupied a central place in the minds of Asian Americans. Changing demographics and residential mobility in contemporary Asian America make it more salient than ever before. However, this issue has concerned native-born generations more than the first generation, because native-born generations are caught in the insider/outsider divide: they suffer from the paradoxical experience of being in America but not fully a part of it. Both immigrants and their US-born children encounter this paradoxical experience, yet their feelings about it are different.

Mainstream American society pressures all immigrants to “fit in” and “not rock the boat.” The society also expects immigrants, however diverse or initially disadvantaged they may be, to assimilate into the mainstream as quickly as possible. Behind this ideology of assimilationism, however, there is an invisible force for inclusion and exclusion. Writing in 1782, J. Hector St. John de Crevecoeur described an American as “either an European or the descendant of an European.” More than a century later, Israel Zangwill (1914) characterized an American as an “immaculate, well-dressed, accent-free Anglo.” These kinds of definitions of “American,” widely if often unconsciously held, make it hard, if not impossible, for people to feel fully American if they happen to be nonwhite, including those whose ancestors settled on this land long before the first Europeans reached American shores. The 1790 National Origin Act prohibited all but free white persons from becoming US citizens. Thus, not all outsider groups were afforded the privilege of becoming American. A second-generation Chinese American in her sixties explained her isolation from mainstream American society and her socially imposed otherness in these words:

The truth is, no matter how American you think you are or try to be, you do not look “American.” If you have almond-shaped eyes, straight black hair, and a yellow complexion, you are a foreigner by default. People will ask where you come from but won't be satisfied until they hear you name a foreign country. And they will naturally compliment your perfect English.¹⁰

Immigrants are deemed “outsiders,” and they tend to cope with their alienation from the immigrant perspective. Historically, people of Asian descent were considered members of “inferior races” and were negatively portrayed as the “indispensable enemy” and as the “yellow peril.” No matter how hard they tried to accommodate to American ways, Asian immigrants and Americans of Asian ancestry were considered undesirable and unassimilable aliens (Chan 1991). The Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, the first immigration act in US history to exclude an entire category of immigrants purely on the basis of national origin, is a prime

example. The forced removal and incarceration of Japanese Americans during World War II is another case in point. The federal government, under provision of President Franklin D. Roosevelt's Executive Order 9066, justified these actions as a "military necessity" vital to the national defense of the United States (despite the fact of evidence confirming the loyalty of Japanese Americans). In contrast, no such categorical treatments were imposed on German Americans and Italian Americans.

As a reactive strategy to resist subjugation and discrimination, Asian immigrants retreated into their own ethnic communities, rebuilding ethnic institutions that resembled those found in the homeland and relying on one another for moral and practical supports (Zhou 2009). Extreme adversity allowed them to develop a clear sense of their position in the host society as "foreigners" and to maintain tangible ties to their ethnic community and their homeland, which became internalized as part of their shared experience. Since most Asian immigrants chose to come to the United States to seek better opportunities either for themselves or for their children, their shared experience of marginalization reinforced their determination to push their children into the mainstream by choosing a path of least resistance (Kitano 1969). For example, prewar issei (first generation) drew on extensive ethnic resources in developing trade and business associations to negotiate favorable arrangements with the larger economy and to support their children's education (Matsumoto 1993; Nishi 1995). War-traumatized Japanese American parents or grandparents were reluctant to share wartime memories with their children and grandchildren for fear of hurting their children's chances of social integration (Takezawa 2000). Post-1965 Korean immigrants pushed their children toward prestigious universities because they looked to their children to regain the social status the parents had lost in the host society (Zhou and Kim 2006).

Unlike most members of the first generation who tend to avoid arousing antagonism by subscribing to the dominant society's mode of behavior—hard work, education, delayed gratification, nonconfrontational attitudes in the face of injustice—their offspring, American citizens by birth, are likely to fully embrace the principles of freedom, equality, and civil liberties on which citizenship is based. They are unlikely to think of their parents' home country as a place to which they might return, nor do they use it as a point of reference by which to assess their progress in the new land. Rather, their expectations are governed by the same standards to which other Americans aspire, and it is by those standards that US-born Asian Americans assess themselves and are assessed by others. However, American society is not color-blind, and the phenotypes of the second generation subject them to the same types of discrimination and injustice faced by the first generation regardless of how long they have been in the United States. A third-generation Japanese American

from Monterey Park, California, expressed frustration at being objectified as a “foreigner”:

Asian Americans fought for decades against discrimination and racial prejudice. We want to be treated just like everybody else, like Americans. You see, I get real angry when people come up to me and tell me how good my English is. They say: “Oh, you have no accent. Where did you learn English?” Where did I learn English? Right here in America. I was born here like they were. We really hated it when people assume that just because Asian Americans look different we were foreigners. It took us a long time to get people to see this point, to be sensitized to it. Now the new immigrants are setting us back. People see me now and they automatically treat me as an immigrant. I really hate that. The worst thing is that these immigrants don’t understand why I am angry. (Cheng and Yang 1996, 305)

An examination of today’s Asian American populations highlights the demarcation between the different generations. Because of the recency of immigration, this group remains primarily an immigrant group, in which the first generation makes up more than two-thirds of the total Asian American population.¹¹ It is only among Japanese Americans and Chinese Americans that we notice a sizeable third or fourth generation. Among Asian American children under eighteen years of age, more than 90 percent are either foreign-born or children of foreign-born parents. Growing up in the context of an immigrant family is extremely difficult for Asian American children. Parents often place multiple pressures on their children to “do and say the right things” or to “act white” as a means of moving into the mainstream and accessing resources typically reserved for “insiders.” In the process of growing up, the children often find themselves vacillating between the outsider’s world from which they came and an insider’s world into which they were born; they are increasingly ambivalent about their conflicting identities.

Many second-generation Asian Americans of the 1960s and 1970s went through a period of profound confusion, feeling trapped by the ironies of being in America but not a part of it. In the wake of the Asian American movement, young Asian Americans who entered American institutions of higher education began to confront these identity issues. The movement forged a space in which these young people not only shared their own personal experiences of racism and suffering in American society but also began to articulate an Asian American consciousness and to refashion their own identities in ways that were meaningful to their experiences—an Asian American identity. At a time when Asian Americans began to empower themselves across panethnic lines and to raise an ethnic consciousness to a new level for future generations, it is ironic that much of the shame and frustration that previously engulfed the second generation has resurfaced among the children of contemporary immigrants from Asia. Some of

the children, especially those who live in suburban, white, middle-class neighborhoods, internalize the negative stereotypes that society imposes upon their parents' generation and have undergone traumatic, even suicidal, identity crises, in which they feel ashamed of who they are, try to become who they are not, and end up being neither, as so vividly described in "A Letter to My Sister" (Park, this volume). A Chinese American college student, born in the early 1980s, reveals her confusion as a teenager:

As a child, I had a very difficult time coping with my ethnic identity. I was hesitant to call myself American because as I perceived it, American meant all the beautiful Anglo children in my classes. Yet I was also hesitant to call myself Chinese for two reasons. First, I had no clear concept of what Chinese was besides the fact that my parents were from China. [Second,] I did not feel Chinese. I did not want to be Chinese. I wanted to be White . . . I tried to hide my identity. I buried it deep within my subconscious, became oblivious to it. Yet every so often, it would be invoked. . . . Perhaps the most notorious manifestation of my shame was my inability to answer the simple question, "What are you?" . . . When I was confronted with questions concerning my racial background, I found myself unable to answer. . . . Unable to utter the simple words, "I am Chinese." I just could not do it. It was too painful for some reason. The words seemed too dissonant and distasteful. So many times I simply shrugged and said: "I don't know."¹²

The pressure to assimilate and the conditional acceptance by mainstream society takes a heavier toll on the second generation growing up in suburban white middle-class neighborhoods than on those who live in inner-city ethnic enclaves (Sung 1987). Within the enclave, the homeland is transplanted, ancestral culture and values are honored and practiced as a way of life, and ethnic pride is invigorated. Outside the enclave, ethnicity is subject to the rank order of the racial stratification system, operating under the assumption that ethnic traits should be abandoned in order to become "American." In the midst of an identity crisis, US-born children who are seemingly assimilated structurally may find that they lack a homeland on which they can fall back and an ethnic space in which they can express their fear and anxieties. This explains in part why so many Asian American college students demand ethnic studies classes. These ethnic studies classes do not merely serve to disseminate information or transport knowledge but provide a space in which Asian Americans address the issue of identity, allowing them to release negative feelings about themselves as well as inner tensions and anxieties. These classes let them rebuild a sense of self-worth and a group identity as a means of ethnic empowerment.

The Salience of Ethnicity

Identity crises are not uncommon among adolescents as they grow into adulthood, but they are not necessarily defining experiences for all members of native-born generations. Since the birth of the Asian American movement, a vibrant and multifaceted ethnic culture has emerged and been reconstructed among US-born Asian Americans in their attempt to reclaim their identity. This culture is neither mainstream American nor clearly associated with the immigrant generation. It is a hybrid form that has come to assume tremendous significance among Asian Americans as a viable means of resistance and compromise within the existing power structure. This phenomenon indicates the fluid nature of ethnicity.

The sociologist William Yancey and his colleagues argue that the emergence of an ethnic culture has relatively little to do with the country of origin but more to do with the structure of opportunity in America. Instead of viewing the transplanted cultural heritage as the principal defining characteristic of an ethnic group, these scholars suggest that the development and persistence of ethnicity is a paradoxical process. On the one hand, it is defined in the context of frequent association and interaction with others of common origins and cultural heritage. On the other hand, it is dependent on structural conditions that characterize the positions of groups in American society and create common experiences and interests, thereby setting the potential for collective mobilization around shared goals. Ultimately, it is “a manifestation of the way populations are organized in terms of interaction patterns, institution, personal values, attitudes, lifestyle, and presumed consciousness of kind”—the result of a process that continues to unfold (Yancey, Juliani, and Erikson 1976, 400). Drawing on this reasoning, we see that Asian Americans develop different patterns of ethnic identification according to the length of time in the United States, internal group dynamics, and structural situations that the particular immigrant group and its descendants have encountered.

As we have discussed, identity formation varies across generations and national origin groups. The immigrant generation generally reaffirms its ethnic identity on the basis of homeland cultures and life experiences not only through ethnic practices but also through memories of its lived experiences in the homeland or during the process of movement. For example, Southeast Asian refugees share the common experience of having lived through internal power struggles in their home countries, the horrors of war, and the ordeal of exile and death. These life-threatening experiences become the basis for ethnic solidarity. Drastic cultural changes and adverse societal treatments or disadvantages associated with immigrant status in the host society can reinforce ethnic identity, as in the case of ethnic enclaves where transnational ties and kinship networks remain

strong and homeland cultures are often frozen in time as the result of a collective, concerted effort to preserve them.

US-born Asian Americans and those who arrived in the United States as infants or as school-age children, in contrast, usually do not seize on traditional cultural symbols as a mode of defining their ethnicity. Rather, they tend to build their identities largely on the basis of mediating *interpretive memories* of homeland cultures in which they have never personally lived, and their own diverse life experiences in the United States. Living in immigrant families and in (or close to) ethnic communities has made life in the homeland a continuing reality because parents often communicate to children with a strong sense of determination and instill in them a sense of origin. Close proximity to kinship networks and ethnic enclaves certainly exerts an important effect on the US-born, providing an infrastructure that keeps alive the memories of homeland cultures. The collective memory of Chinese exclusion, the US colonization of the Philippines, and the incarceration of Japanese Americans serve as pivotal organizational principles for ethnic identity among US-born Chinese Americans, Filipino Americans and Japanese Americans, respectively. The support of Asian American donors to the Museum of the Chinese in the Americas in New York and the Japanese American National Museum in Los Angeles is living proof that even the most “assimilated” of Asian Americans clearly retain vital links to their ethnic culture and to the community that sustains it.

Often, however, actual experiences in American society outweigh memories. Transplanted cultural heritage is no longer the requirement or the defining characteristic of ethnicity for the native-born. Rather, the emergence and persistence of ethnicity depends on the structural conditions of the host society and the position that the immigrant groups occupies in that social structure. The treatment of Asian Americans as foreigners, the glass ceiling, and racially motivated hate crimes all serve to reaffirm ethnic identity. However, this ethnic identity, even when it is affiliated with a national origin, differs for the first generation and its native-born offspring in that the ethnicity of the first generation has a taken-for-granted nature, whereas that of native-born generations is derived both from the collective memory of the historical experience and from the native-born generations’ actual experience in a more self-conscious, reflexive way.

This vibrant emergent ethnic culture transcends the spatial boundaries of ethnic enclaves as well as the symbolic meaning of ethnicity. It is a culture characterized by structures that promote cooperation among coethnics while adopting activities and organizations (e.g., ethnic churches, sports clubs, trade guilds, political organizations) as a means of resistance (Espiritu 1992; Tuan 1999). Yet, what ethnicity means, stands for, or symbolizes differs from region to region, city to city, and town to town in the vast expanse of the United States. Being Japanese American in Hawaii or Chinese American in Monterey Park or Vietnamese

American in Little Saigon is not the same as having those identities in New York, Houston, or New Orleans.

Is this emergent ethnicity symbolic? The sociologist Herbert Gans asserts that “as the functions of ethnic cultures and groups diminish and identity becomes the primary way of being ethnic, ethnicity takes on an expressive rather than instrumental function in people’s lives, becoming more of a leisure-time activity” (Gans 1979, 9). Among the features of symbolic ethnicity is that it does not carry with it material consequences and does not serve to enhance group solidarity. Indeed, ethnic identity associated with a homeland has become blurred among the second or third generations, who have lost their ancestral languages, have intermarried at rates far exceeding the national average, and no longer involve themselves with their ethnic communities on a daily basis, making their ethnicity “symbolic.” Our argument about interpretive memories of homeland culture points to the importance of symbolic ethnicity. Clearly, ethnicity is not an either/or matter but rather a variable outcome that varies in its intensity. As we have noted earlier, Asian Americans, both foreign-born and US-born, experience high levels of educational attainment, occupational mobility, and residential integration, have high rates of intermarriage, and rapidly lose facility in the native language; hence, much of Asian ethnicity may be optional. As they climb up the socioeconomic ladder in American society, many established Asian Americans may have more choices as to whether they want to be Asian and how Asian they should be when they want to.

At the societal level, however, we argue that the notion of symbolic ethnicity does not always apply well to Asian Americans or to other racial minority groups, since being non-ethnic American is still not an option for them, as it is for most European immigrants and their offspring (Takezawa 2000; Waters 1990). The outcry that “America does not include me, only a part of me” is heard from many US-born, “well assimilated” Asian Americans. This suggests that unless the whole racial perception of Americans changes and includes other groups as Americans, emergent ethnicity, often in the form of panethnicity, will continue to remain instrumental for the excluded social groups. Such emergent panethnicity serves as both a defense mechanism against racism and an empowering mechanism for unity and solidarity.

Ethnicity is situational and structurally conditioned. Under certain circumstances, it can evolve into panethnicity, a form of ethnic aggregation typically oriented toward achieving certain material ends and empowerment. In thinking about panethnicity, we draw on the work of the sociologists David Lopez and Yen Espiritu, who link it to a set of cultural and structural preconditions: shared cultural values and life experiences in American society, imposed societal perception and treatment as one phenotypical group, and the internal need for political mobilization to fight for minority rights and to protect group interests (Lopez and Espiritu 1990). We add that rapid language switch to English and

increasing interethnic and interracial marriages also contribute to the formation of panethnicity. Today, Asian Americans intermarry extensively with members of other racial or ethnic groups. In Los Angeles County, for example, about one-third of Asian Americans, and about half of all second-generation Asian Americans marry outside their ethnic groups. Ambiguous phenotype may ease social constraints imposed by the existing racial stratification system while fostering a strong sense of panethnicity among multiracial or multiethnic Americans.

However, lumping together all peoples of Asian ancestry complicates the notion of ethnicity and its subsequent application to a particular ethnic group, because panethnicity accounts neither for regional or national differences nor for the historical legacies of intergroup conflicts. At this juncture, the term “Asian American,” in and of itself, assumes a political agenda for those who subscribe to it, and panethnicity remains a political identity for instrumental purposes. The Asian American community today is, and continues to be, marked by tremendous diversity in the era of high immigration. Diverse languages and religions and differing historical legacies of domination and colonization in Asia make it unlikely that a panethnic coalition will develop in the near future. Differences in class background among the immigrant generation and divergent modes of incorporation of that generation can also deter the formation of panethnicity. The success of Asian Americans’ integration into American society as individuals can both enhance and weaken their ability to act collectively. Also, while it is true that discrimination and violence against one Asian group serve to unite Asian Americans, they can also create intragroup conflict. During World War II, the US government singled out Japanese Americans as enemies and targets for incarceration. Fearing similar treatment, some Chinese Americans found themselves constantly invoking their Chinese ethnicity and even wore buttons with derogative anti-Japanese words to distinguish themselves. The negative stereotypes about welfare dependency and gang violence among Southeast Asians also cause some Asian American groups to distance themselves from them and even blame them for their plight.

The Assimilation Problem

The issue of assimilation has been the core of a classic scholarly debate on immigration, and racial and ethnic relations. Classical assimilation theory predicts a linear trajectory toward structural integration into the mainstream of society. In this view, the children and the grandchildren of the immigrants move beyond the status of the first generation and progressively become less distinct from other Americans. This particular perspective shares a series of assumptions: outsider groups, however diverse and initially disadvantaged, all absorb a common culture and gain equal access to the opportunity structure; they do so in a more or less natural way, gradually deserting old cultural and behavioral patterns in

favor of new ones; and the whole process, once set in motion, moves inevitably and irreversibly toward the dissolution of the original group. Consequently, observable ethnic differences are largely a function of time and generational status in the United States. In some cases, the time span for assimilation may be prolonged, but, in the end, distinctive ethnic characteristics eventually fade, retaining only some symbolic importance (Alba and Nee 2003; Gans 1979; Gordon 1964; Warner and Srole 1945).

Assimilation theories arose as an abstraction from the experience of earlier European immigration. The theoretical reflections developed largely while the process of immigrant adaptation was under way. Now that it is over, one can safely conclude that the descendants of the 1880 to 1920 wave have overcome earlier disadvantages, achieving parity with, if not outdistancing, “white” Americans of English ancestry, or what Milton Gordon calls the “core cultural group” (Gordon 1964). Unfortunately, assimilation theories provide no account of why this outcome should have transpired—unless one subscribes to that variant of the modernization theory that most earlier writers embraced but many contemporary social scientists have now challenged. Most important, past success may be due to the specific circumstances encountered by earlier immigrants and their offspring—the fact that between the 1920s and the 1950s, America experienced a long period of restricted immigration, which almost certainly weakened immigrants’ attachment to their culture and patterns of group affiliation. Should this be the case, the past is unlikely to prove a useful guide to the future, since we appear to be headed for more, not less, immigration in the years to come.

Assimilationism—the ideology that imposes the dominant core culture on all immigrants to American society—is highly exclusive. The “melting pot” does not wholeheartedly embrace non-European immigrants. The experiences of African Americans are a case in point. Nathan Glazer (1993) shows how racism serves to exclude African Americans from assimilating or sharing in the opportunities of economic and social mobility. Racism and prejudice have also affected the situation of Asian Americans, although to a different degree. Examples are ample, but we point out three of the most obvious.

First, the perception of Asian Americans as “foreigners” has imposed and perpetuated the “otherness” on the group. As we have discussed in detail in the previous section, it is the socially imposed category based on phenotype, rather than acculturation and social mobility, that governs how group members are received and treated in American society. Speaking perfect English, effortlessly practicing mainstream cultural values, and even intermarrying members of the dominant group may help reduce this “otherness” at the individual level but have little effect on the group as a whole, given the relatively small size of the third or later generations of the Asian American population (only 10 percent of the total) and the high levels of recent immigration.

Second, the image of “the yellow peril,” although largely repudiated in the post–World War II period, has repeatedly resurfaced throughout American history, especially in situations when the United States is at odds with immigrants’ ancestral homelands in Asia. The bombing of Pearl Harbor during World War II turned Japanese immigrants and Americans of Japanese ancestry into enemies who were forcibly exiled from their homes and put into internment camps. The communist takeover of China in the late 1940s and the subsequent Cold War made Chinese Americans of the 1950s prime suspects of treason and espionage. The perceived economic threat from Japan in the 1980s led to the murder of Vincent Chin, a Chinese American, mistaken for a Japanese, who was beaten to death by disgruntled unemployed autoworkers in Detroit. The renewed spy stereotype is currently manifested in the case of a Taiwan-born scientist, Wen Ho Lee, who was convicted of stealing nuclear secrets for China in the court of public opinion before even appearing in a court of law. This litany of examples is endless.

Third, the “model minority” stereotype has reinforced the “otherness” of Asian Americans. It is important to note that this stereotype derives from a larger political agenda, serving the ideological function of delegitimizing African American (in particular) claims for equalization of outcomes as opposed to equalization of opportunities. Although Asian Americans as a group are above average on just about any socioeconomic indicator that counts, the “model minority” stereotype obscures the very real problems that many highly “successful” Asians encounter. In particular, highly skilled professionals, who are most definitely part of the middle, if not the upper-middle, class, are not doing quite as well as their non-Hispanic white counterparts; they experience disproportionately underemployment because of overqualification and overwork (Zhou and Kamo 1994). Furthermore, the stereotype paints a one-sided picture of the Asian American population, obscuring the plight of those who are not doing well and thus further absolving the broader society of any responsibility for redress. There are immigrant workers who are doing poorly, some subjected to severe exploitation. Some groups—Laotians, Hmong, and Cambodians—are still struggling at the very bottom of the social ladder, facing the risk of being trapped in the urban underclass, and others—perhaps the Filipinos—may be stuck in the lower middle class, showing trends of downward mobility (Oropesa and Landale 1997).

In sum, the notion of assimilation, whether it is manifested in a straight line or bumpy line, seems to clearly imply a *single* line—an idea that is very difficult to reconcile with the historical record of large and significant differences in the rate at which various groups move ahead in American society. Because of the complexity of the reality with its multifaceted and dynamic nature, it is difficult to comprehend the experiences of today’s racial minorities, Asian Americans included, within the assimilationist framework that makes explicit or implicit Anglo-conformist assumptions. Assimilationism may still be a social or moral

imperative imposed on immigrants by the dominant culture, but it may not necessarily be the imperative toward which all immigrant groups and their succeeding generations are striving.

Discussion and Conclusions

Diversity is the hallmark of contemporary Asian America. The influx of Asian immigrants in response to the 1965 Hart-Celler Act and broader economic, social, and geopolitical factors has brought new challenges for the adaptation of new immigrants and their children into society. As the community continues to grow in number, so too will their representation in the broad cultural, social, and economic milieu that we typify as “mainstream American society.”

The implications of the dramatic changes in contemporary Asian America that we have just described are particularly relevant for the development of a coherent vision for future Asian America. First and foremost, diversity in national origins produces stark disparities within the Asian American community. National origins evoke drastic differences in homeland cultures, such as languages, religions, foodways, and customs; histories of international relations; contexts of emigration; reception in the host society; and adaptation patterns. Such differences persist most significantly in the private domain, affecting not only the immigrant generation, but also the native-born generations. For some national origin groups, such as the Chinese and Indians, internal differences in languages or dialects and religions are quite substantial. While ethnic diversity among the second and third generations may be blurred because of rapid switch to English and high rates of out-marriages, it is extremely difficult to group everybody under a pan-Asian umbrella at the individual level. While increasing differences within an emerging Asian America may create obstacles for panethnic coalitions, the connections between children of Asian immigrants and those of Latin American and other national origins can create new possibilities for racial formations in a society that is no longer defined by the black-white racial paradigm and is becoming increasingly multiracial and multiethnic. For example, Latin American immigration is reshaping the incorporation processes of Asian children of immigrants as well as influencing the mechanisms of Asian American panethnic consciousness (Ocampo, this volume).

Second, socioeconomic diversity gives rise to diverse mobility patterns. New immigrants may continue to follow the traditional bottom-up route to social mobility, starting their American life in isolated urban enclaves, but some segment of this urban population may be permanently trapped in poverty with dim prospects for the future. Those with sufficient social and economic resources may simply bypass the bottom starting line, moving directly into mainstream labor markets and settling directly into suburban middle-class communities (Portes and Zhou 1993). These trajectories to social mobility not only affect

life chances of the first generation but also have profound social implications for the new second generation, since the current state and future prospects of immigrant offspring are related to the advantages or disadvantages that accrue through parental socioeconomic status.

Socioeconomic diversity leads to divergent destinies, creating a bifurcated distribution of the Asian American population along class lines. Some national origin groups, such as the Chinese, Filipino, Japanese, Koreans, and Asian Indians, have converged with the general US population, with the rich and the poor on the ends and an ever-growing affluent class in the middle. But, many others, especially the most recent refugee groups, are struggling in the most underprivileged segment of US society. Consequently, class bifurcation toward two ends of society's class spectrum will likely lead to fragmentation of the larger Asian American community, creating new obstacles for political mobilization and ethnic solidarity. Bifurcation also affects the new second generation. Unlike the second generation of the 1960 and 1970s, most of whom grew up in segregated urban enclaves, a visible proportion of today's second generation is growing up in affluent Euro-American neighborhoods in suburbia. Members of the suburban middle class maintain little contact with their working-class coethnics in urban enclaves and show limited interest in working-class issues.

Moreover, socioeconomic diversity leads to divergent destinies, creating a bifurcated distribution of the Asian American population along class lines. Some Asian immigrant groups have converged with middle-class American, but many others, especially the most recent refugee groups, are struggling in the most underprivileged segment of American society. Consequently, class bifurcation toward both ends of society's class spectrum will likely lead to fragmentation of the larger Asian American community, which will hinder political mobilization and panethnic solidarity. Bifurcation also likely affects the second generation. Unlike the second generation of the 1960s and 1970s, most of whom grew up in segregated urban enclaves, a visible proportion of today's second generation is growing up in affluent white middle-class suburbs. Members of the suburban middle-class coethnics may have fewer ties to their working-class coethnics in urban enclaves and show limited interest in working-class community issues.

Third, diverse settlement patterns also have long-term implications for the development of a cohesive Asian American community. Those who are currently segregated in the inner city are confronted with a reality more daunting than the one faced by their earlier counterparts. Today, the United States has an emerging "hourglass" economy in which movement from bottom to top has gotten progressively more difficult. Those newcomers who are poorly educated and lack marketable skills may find themselves stalled or, even worse, stumbling beneath the ranks of the lower working class, either because they are unable to obtain employment or because the jobs they do obtain do not pay a decent family wage. Consequently, they and their children may become trapped in poverty and

isolated from mainstream American society. While successful structural integration may not automatically lead to social acceptance, those who have achieved residential mobility are undoubtedly more privileged, enjoying comfortable homes, safe neighborhoods, quality schools, and more channels to mobility.

Last but not least, immigration complicates intergenerational relations and ethnic solidarity. US-born Asian Americans, especially those assumed to be “assimilated,” have been rudely reawakened with renewed images of being “foreigners.” Stereotyped images of “American” create both psychological and practical problems for native-born Americans who phenotypically resemble the new arrivals. One frequently hears of the harassment of US-born Mexican Americans suspected of being undocumented immigrants and of comments about third-generation Japanese Americans’ “good English.” The children, born in the United States and similar to other American children, suffer from persistent disadvantages merely because they look “foreign” (US Commission on Civil Rights 1992, 1998). While they are infuriated by their unfair treatment as foreigners, US-born Asian Americans are also caught between including immigrants in their struggle for racial equality and excluding them. Similar to other Americans in speech, thought, and behavior, US-born Asian Americans often hold values about labor rights, individualism, civil liberty, and, ultimately, the ideology of assimilationism that are different from those of their foreign-born counterparts. These differences, intertwined with the acculturation gap between immigrant and native-born generations, have impeded ethnic coalition, ideological consensus, and collective action (Zhou 2001).

Negotiating differences and coalition building within this very heterogeneous ethnic community will continue to remain the foremost priority in the twenty-first century. Policies reflecting the interests and needs of Asian Americans must develop a flexible framework to incorporate the diversity that characterizes the contemporary community. New generations of Asian Americans will have to vie for their own place within their respective communities and challenge stereotypes that serve to denigrate their agency in mainstream American society. Although Asian Americans will continue to rally (as they have historically) around issues that unite them on the basis of a shared sense of racial identity—ethnic stereotyping, hate crimes, economic and political scapegoating, and the glass ceiling—specific national and cultural interests espoused by Asian American ethnic groups will demand innovative approaches to promoting the continued development of pan-Asian coalitions while reflecting interethnic differences.

NOTES

- 1 The number includes 1.6 million formerly unauthorized aliens and 1.1 million special agricultural workers who were granted permanent resident status under the provisions of the Immigration Reform and Control Act of 1986 (Zhou 2001).
- 2 The number of Asian immigrants excludes those from Iran, Israel, and Turkey, except for 1991, when the Asian share dropped to 18 percent due to the sudden increase in the legalizes under IRCA, most of whom were Mexicans or Central Americans.

- 3 *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics: 2012*, http://www.dhs.gov/sites/default/files/publications/ois_yb_2012.pdf (accessed January 10, 2015).
- 4 Pew Research Center (2012).
- 5 A small number of Asian Indians were present at the time. They were, however, classified as “Hindu” in the 1920, 1930, and 1940 censuses, as “white” in 1950 and 1960, and as “Asian or Pacific Islander” since 1970 (Nash 1997).
- 6 As defined by the US Bureau of the Census, PMSA stands for primary metropolitan statistical area and MSA for metropolitan statistical area, terms that generally refer to central cities.
- 7 US Asian American Population map, http://www.pewsocialtrends.org/asianamericans-graphics/st_12-06-17_aa_map/ (accessed January 27, 2015).
- 8 Hope Yen and Ben Nuckols, “Urban Chinatowns Wane as Asians Head to the Suburbs,” *Huffington Post*, January 19, 2012, http://www.huffingtonpost.com/2012/01/19/urban-chinatowns-decline_n_1217122.html (accessed January 27, 2015).
- 9 Originally quoted in Bernard Wong (1982, 33). Also cited in Morrison G. Wong (1995, 86).
- 10 Personal communication with a retired Chinatown activist in New York.
- 11 The detailed generation breakdown among Asian Americans is as follows: 65 percent belong to the first generation (foreign-born), 25 percent the second generation (US-born of foreign-born parentage), and 10 percent the third or later generations (US-born of US-born parentage), compared to 9 percent, 11 percent, and 80 percent, respectively, in the general US population. Figures are from the 2000–2002 Current Population Survey of the US Census Bureau.
- 12 Class discussion on ethnic identity, UCLA, March 1999.

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